



Guidelines for Writing Group Contract

Effective teamwork hinges on clear communication, accountability, and mutual understanding. To ensure the success of your group, all members must carefully read, discuss, and agree upon the contract details outlined below.

Rationale

According to concepts from Organizational Behavior, there are five stages of group development: forming, storming, norming, performing, and adjourning. During the forming stage, groups tend to communicate in indirect polite ways rather than more directly. The storming stage, characterized by conflict, can often be productive, but may consume excessive amounts of time and energy. In this stage it is important to listen well for differing expectations. Next, during the norming stage, groups formulate roles and standards, increasing trust and communication. This norming stage is characterized by agreement on procedures, reduction in role ambiguity, and increased “we-ness” or unity. These developments generally are precursors to the performing stage, during which groups achieve their goals, are highly task oriented, and focus on performance and production. When the task has been completed, the group adjourns.

To accelerate a group’s development, a group contract is generated to establish procedures and roles in order to move the group more quickly into the performing stage. This process of generating a group contract can actually help jump-start a group's collaborative efforts by immediately focusing the group members on a definite task. The group members must communicate and negotiate in order to identify the quality of work they all wish to achieve, and the level of group participation and individual accountability they all feel comfortable with.

Successful group performance depends on personal individual accountability. In a group environment, individuals are usually effectively motivated to maximize their own rewards and minimize their own costs. However, conflicts can arise when individualistic motives or behaviors disrupt team-oriented goals. For example, conflict can stem from an unequal division of resources. When group members believe they are receiving too little for what they are giving, they sometimes reduce their effort and turn in work of lower quality. Such "free riding" occurs most frequently when individual contributions are combined into a single product or performance, and individual effort is perceived as unequal. At this point, some individual group members may take on extra responsibilities while other group members may reduce their own efforts or withdraw from the group completely. These behaviors may engender anger, frustration, or isolation—resulting in a dysfunctional group and poor quality of work. However, with a well-formulated group contract, such obstacles can usually be avoided.



Group Contract Assignment

Your group contract template is divided into three major sections:

1. Establishing Team Procedures
2. Identifying Expectations
3. Specifying Consequences for Failing to Follow Procedures and Fulfill Expectations

Since the basic purpose of this group contract is to accelerate your group's development, to increase individual accountability for group tasks, and to reduce the possibility for group conflict, make your contract **as specific as possible**:

1. Specify each task as detailed as possible
2. Specify each step in a procedure or process as detailed as possible
3. Specify the exact person(s) responsible for each specific task, and
4. Specify the exact time and exact place for completion or submission of each task.

The more specifically you describe your group expectations, roles, and procedures, the greater chance you have for a successful group experience.

Use the Group Contract template to discuss and finalize your group roles, procedures, and standards. Complete, sign, and submit your finalized contract.

Once your group contract has been developed, your group is ready to begin work on collaborative assignments. However, you may soon find that your group is not working as well as you had hoped. This is normal but needs to be attended to immediately. Perhaps your group is simply not following the established contract procedures or roles as strictly as you should be, or perhaps you need to change some of the procedures or roles as outlined in your contract. Call a group meeting immediately to discuss and resolve the challenges your group is facing; **do not delay**. Seek guidance from your instructor, TA, or preceptor to resolve any conflicts so that you will have the most positive group experience possible. *Note: The contract below is inspired by a team contract from the University of Arizona, Math Department.*